

Consumer uncertainty: The influence of anticipatory emotions on ambivalence, attitudes, and intentions

COLLEEN C. BEE^{1*} and ROBERT MADRIGAL²

¹College of Business, Oregon State University, 200 Bexell Hall, Corvallis, OR 97331, USA

²Lundquist College of Business, University of Oregon, 1208 University of Oregon, Eugene, OR 97403, USA

ABSTRACT

Specific emotions and their combinations have important implications for consumer experiences and decisions. Therefore, emotional response is examined from a future temporal perspective in order to investigate the effect of anticipatory emotions on consumer ambivalence, attitudes, and intentions. In the first study, anticipatory emotions, compared with outcome-based emotions, are found to be central in prospective consumption situations, and this combination of emotions is most likely to occur when consumers are presented with conflicting information. Furthermore, anticipatory mixed emotions (i.e., anticipatory ambivalence), in contrast to outcome-based mixed emotions, were the greatest contributor to consumer discomfort and uncertainty regarding future consumption. The second study builds on the first by considering the effect of anticipatory ambivalence on attitudes and intentions in the context of a prospective purchase situation. Ambivalence was found to mediate the effect of evaluative information on intentions, as well as moderate the relationship between attitudes and intentions. Thus, the uncertainty associated with anticipatory emotions negatively affects intentions, as well as the relationship between attitudes and intentions. The theoretical and practical implications are discussed. Copyright © 2013 John Wiley & Sons, Ltd.

Selecting a vacation destination, investing in the stock market, deciding on a surgeon, or planning to visit a new restaurant are all decisions based on assumptions made about something that will happen in the future. They are future-oriented or prospective in the sense that the outcomes of consumption are not known at the time of purchase. Moreover, each of these situations is multi-faceted, which suggests that some aspects of the future outcome may be judged favorably and others not. For example, on-line reviews for a vacation resort might have conflicting comments about various aspects of the experience. Some customers might praise the décor and furnishings but others might complain about the service and food in restaurants located on the property.

Uncertainty regarding a prospective purchase is quite common, especially when purchase involvement is high and potential outcomes are not easily assessed. Our research proposes that uncertain purchase situations will elicit anticipatory emotions that inform consumer attitudes and behaviors. Research on consumer emotions has typically considered emotional response to events and experiences that have occurred in either the past or present (e.g., Schoefer, 2008; Williams and Aaker, 2002). Only recently has there been a shift in temporal focus to a consideration of emotional responses to future events (Baumgartner *et al.*, 2008; MacInnis and de Mello, 2005; Winterich and Haws, 2011).

The current research builds on this emerging literature and makes two important contributions. First, although previous research has investigated mixed emotion experiences (e.g., Williams and Aaker, 2002), such mixtures have not been considered from a future temporal perspective. This is an interesting research gap given that many purchase

and consumption experiences elicit mixed emotions (e.g., Richins, 1997; Ruth *et al.*, 2002) and that consumers are unlikely to make an important purchase decision without referencing their feelings toward future outcomes. Emotions serve as an important source of information in decision making (Bagozzi *et al.*, 2000; Clore *et al.*, 2001); thus, the consideration of how conflicting mixed emotions are likely to affect consumer attitudes and intentions represents an important area of inquiry (Zembarain and Johar, 2007).

The second contribution is the consideration of two specific anticipatory emotions that have received little research attention in the consumer behavior literature: hope and fear. Hope arises from the prospect of a desirable future outcome and inspires favorable attitudes and approach behaviors, whereas fear results from the prospect of an undesirable future outcome and leads to unfavorable attitudes and avoidance behaviors (Baumgartner *et al.*, 2008; MacInnis and de Mello, 2005; Winterich and Haws, 2011). A classic advertising concept is that marketers can appeal to either hope or fear. However, our focus is not on appealing to these emotions; instead, we investigate effects related to the mixture of hope and fear prior to consumption. It is interesting that, despite MacInnis and de Mello's (2005) contention that hope and fear have potentially far-reaching effects, research has not explored the mixture of these two conflicting emotions.

Using cognitive appraisal theory as a theoretical foundation, the current research examines how the appraisal dimension of goal congruence and the temporal perspective of when consumption occurs affect perceptions of emotional ambivalence, as well as attitudinal responses and behavioral intentions to a service offering. In the following sections, relevant literature is reviewed, and we report the results of two experiments. Theoretical and practical implications are then discussed.

*Correspondence to: Colleen C. Bee, College of Business, Oregon State University, 200 Bexell Hall, Corvallis, OR 97331, USA.
E-mail: colleen.bee@bus.oregonstate.edu

STUDY 1

An overarching purpose of the first study is to demonstrate that anticipatory emotions are distinct from outcome-based emotions. Such a distinction is necessary given our focus on prospective consumption situations. A secondary purpose of this study is to investigate whether anticipatory (vs. outcome-based) emotions are the primary contributors to consumer ambivalence in a prospective consumption situation. Feelings of discomfort and uncertainty over potential future outcomes are expected to be more sensitive to anticipatory (vs. outcome-based) emotions.

Research investigating affective influences on choice and decision making has tended to take a valence-based approach, such as contrasting positive versus negative feeling states. More recently, work has considered how the tendencies associated with discrete emotions individually affect judgment and choice (e.g., Baumgartner *et al.*, 2008; Kemp and Kopp, 2011; Winterich and Haws, 2011). The theoretical grounding for much of the work on discrete emotions is cognitive appraisal theory, which posits that emotions are elicited on the basis of how events are interpreted rather than on the event itself (Ortony *et al.*, 1988). Considerable research has been conducted on appraisals leading to single-valence emotional responses (e.g., Bougie *et al.*, 2003; Kubberød *et al.*, 2006; Lerner and Keltner, 2000). However, research is limited on the relationship between appraisals and conflicting emotions (Ruth *et al.*, 2002).

A central tenet of appraisal theory is that situations are interpreted along several dimensions (e.g., goal congruence and certainty), and it is the combination of some subset of these dimensions that creates a specific emotion (Lerner and Keltner, 2000). In the case of prospective events where outcomes are uncertain, the appraisal dimension of goal congruence is especially relevant (Lazarus, 1991; Ortony *et al.*, 1988). Goal congruence affects the valence of an emotion based on the likelihood that a prospective outcome will be congruent or incongruent with desires. Hope is elicited in response to an uncertain but possible goal-congruent outcome, whereas fear is evoked in response to the possibility that the outcome will be goal incongruent. Collectively, hope and fear represent anticipatory conflicting emotions.

A helpful corollary for understanding conflicting emotions is research on attitude ambivalence, which examines the presence of both positive and negative attitudes toward a target. When each attitude is measured individually, it is possible to create a measure of objective attitude ambivalence (Priester and Petty, 1996). In the context of emotion, objective ambivalence is the co-existence of two conflicting emotions (Williams and Aaker, 2002). Thus, measuring both hope and fear (or joy and anger) as discrete responses allows for an assessment of objective emotional ambivalence. It is posited that when information related to an uncertain future event is appraised as being both congruent and incongruent with desires (i.e., conflicting information), greater levels of *hope-fear objective ambivalence* will be elicited, compared with *joy-anger objective ambivalence*.

In Study 1, we juxtapose the anticipatory emotions of hope and fear with the outcome-based emotions of joy and

anger (Ortony *et al.*, 1988) to examine their differential effect on consumer ambivalence. In contrast to anticipatory emotions that rely on the prospect of unpredictable future outcomes, outcome-based emotions are associated with a higher degree of outcome certainty where events have already transpired (Ortony *et al.*, 1988). Considering both emotion categories allows for a test of the efficacy of each in a prospective consumption context. The expectation is that when the event has not yet occurred and the outcome is unconfirmed, consumers should feel greater levels of anticipatory (vs. outcome-based) emotions.

The first study examines consumers' emotional responses using a restaurant context. The focus is on the future consumption experience at a restaurant. Specifically, an online restaurant review is manipulated to feature either congruent, incongruent, or conflicting information. The following hypothesis contrasts the experience of anticipatory with outcome-based emotions in a future-oriented consumption situation.

H1: Anticipatory emotions, specifically (a) hope (vs. joy), (b) fear (vs. anger), and (c) hope-fear objective ambivalence (vs. joy-anger objective ambivalence) will be greater in the context of a future-oriented consumption situation.

Prior research on attitude ambivalence indicates that objective ambivalence is antecedent to overall feelings of the uncertainty or discomfort consumers feel as a result of a conflicted state. Such a summary assessment of feelings is referred to as subjective ambivalence (Priester and Petty, 1996). Furthermore, given that specific emotions and their combinations have important implications for subsequent responses (Ruth *et al.*, 2002), it is expected that the subjective ambivalence felt in anticipation of a future consumption experience will be affected differently by various combinations of emotions (e.g., hope and fear vs. joy and anger). Given the uncertainty associated with a future-oriented experience, hope-fear objective ambivalence will likely be a better predictor of subjective ambivalence than will joy-anger objective ambivalence.

The second hypothesis explores how various combinations of emotions predict the discomfort associated with future consumption. This effect is tested after accounting for combinations of single-valence emotions (i.e., hope-joy and fear-anger), as well as joy-anger objective ambivalence. When receiving conflicting information, hope-fear objective ambivalence is expected to be a better predictor of subjective ambivalence than combinations of single-valence emotions and joy-anger objective ambivalence. If supported, the results would indicate that it is the co-occurrence of anticipatory emotions that creates discomfort and uncertainty about future consumption.

H2: In response to a conflicting evaluation about a prospective consumption experience, hope-fear objective ambivalence will explain a significant amount of additional variance in subjective ambivalence after controlling for combinations of hope-joy and fear-anger single-valence emotions and joy-anger objective ambivalence.

Method

Respondents were 160 undergraduate students who participated in a lab setting in exchange for partial course credit. Stimuli included a series of web pages containing an online consent form, background information, and a prospective consumption situation including the congruence stimuli. The background information indicated that respondents would be reading an online evaluation of a restaurant from *Consumer Reports*. The consumption situation informed participants that they had just found a review of a restaurant they were planning on visiting later in the evening with friends for dinner. A restaurant context was chosen because young people (age 18–24 years) have the highest usage rate for casual dining and are a prime target group for marketers in this category (Mintel Reports, 2011). Reviews were manipulated and randomly assigned (see Appendix). Respondents were asked for their emotional reaction to the future consumption situation on the basis of the information provided. The focus is on the future consumption experience at a restaurant where the outcome of their dining experience was uncertain because consumption had not yet taken place.

Congruence, a between-subjects variable (congruent, incongruent, or conflicting), was manipulated by varying the desirability of information on a set of attributes relevant to a restaurant setting. Also included were corresponding comments from customers who were said to have visited the restaurant. Desirable (undesirable) information was presented in the positive (negative) condition. In addition, we also considered a conflicting information condition containing both desirable and undesirable information. The presentation order of desirable and undesirable ratings was alternated in the conflicting review (see Appendix).

Measures

Hope, joy, fear, and anger were operationalized as multi-item constructs created from two sources, Richins (1997) and Ortony *et al.* (1988). Hope included feeling optimistic, hopeful, encouraged, and excited ($\alpha = 0.93$). Joy emotions were happy, pleased, and joyful ($\alpha = 0.91$). Fear included the emotions of feeling worried, tense, nervous, and fearful ($\alpha = 0.84$). The anger emotions included feeling angry, frustrated, and irritated ($\alpha = 0.83$). All emotion items were scored using a unipolar format with a lead in of: Would you feel

(emotion)? If yes, respondents were asked to indicate the extent to which they felt the emotion on a 7-point scale ranging from *slightly* (1) to *extremely* (7) with a midpoint of *moderately* (4). Respondents who reported not feeling an emotion were assigned a 0.

Objective ambivalence was assessed using the Similarity and Intensity Measure advocated by Thompson *et al.* (1995) and further examined by Priester and Petty (1996). This formula incorporates the separate ratings of discrete positive and negative emotions to assess the level of two different conflicting emotions. The discrete emotions of hope and fear were used to calculate the hope–fear objective ambivalence measure, and joy and anger were used to calculate joy–anger objective ambivalence (e.g., $(\text{hope} + \text{fear}) / 2 - |\text{hope} - \text{fear}|$). The same formula was used to calculate the combinations of single-valence emotions of hope–joy and fear–anger.

Subjective ambivalence refers to the overall level of mixed feelings that people have toward an outcome. Consistent with Priester and Petty (1996) and Thompson *et al.* (1995), respondents were asked the extent to which their feelings about the situation were conflicted, mixed, indecisive, and torn ($\alpha = 0.90$). Each item was measured on a 7-point scale (1 = *not at all* and 7 = *a great deal*). The correlations among constructs can be found in Table 1.

Results and discussion

Manipulation checks and anticipatory emotions

A mixed model ANOVA was conducted to test the effectiveness of the restaurant evaluation and to compare anticipatory and outcome-based emotions in the first hypothesis. Level of congruence (congruent vs. incongruent vs. conflicting) was a between-subjects variable, and the three sets of emotions were within-subjects dependent variables. The first set consisted of hope and joy, the second set included fear and anger, and the final emotion set was hope–fear and joy–anger objective ambivalence. The between-subjects effect of congruence ($F(6, 310) = 63.15, p < 0.01$) supported the manipulation of positive, negative, and mixed emotions (see Table 2 for means). Planned contrasts indicated that positive emotions were greater given congruent information ($M = 4.49$) compared with incongruent ($M = 0.34; t = 18.72, p < 0.01$) or conflicting ($M = 0.92; t = 16.23, p < 0.01$) information.

Table 1. Correlations of constructs (Study 1)

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
1 Hope	1.0								
2 Joy	0.86**	1.0							
3 Fear	−0.29**	−0.35**	1.0						
4 Anger	−0.55**	−0.49**	0.46**	1.0					
5 Hope–fear	−0.24**	−0.30**	0.26**	0.03	1.0				
6 Joy–anger	−0.40**	−0.45**	0.13	−0.09	0.51**	1.0			
7 Hope–joy	0.80**	0.92**	−0.31**	−0.38**	−0.39**	−0.55**	1.0		
8 Fear–anger	−0.28**	−0.21**	0.34**	0.64**	−0.22**	−0.08	−0.16	1.0	
9 Subjective ambivalence	−0.25**	−0.33**	0.47**	0.20*	0.53**	0.41**	0.41**	0.09	1.0

Note:

* $p < 0.05$;

** $p < 0.01$.

Table 2. Means and standard deviations (Study 1)

	Condition							
	Overall		Congruent information ($n = 54$)		Incongruent information ($n = 52$)		Conflicting information ($n = 54$)	
	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>
Positive emotions	1.94	2.17	4.49	1.51	0.34	0.63	0.92	1.09
Hope	2.17	2.32	4.77	1.66	0.51	0.95	1.18	1.36
Joy	1.70	2.18	4.21	1.67	0.16	0.56	0.66	1.17
Negative emotions	1.47	1.43	0.37	0.63	2.50	1.44	1.56	1.23
Fear	1.61	1.70	0.62	1.10	2.42	1.83	1.84	1.59
Anger	1.33	1.66	0.13	0.47	2.58	1.68	1.33	1.53
Opposite-valence mixed emotions								
Hope–fear objective ambivalence	2.78	1.54	1.98	1.70	2.95	1.29	3.42	1.27
Joy–anger objective ambivalence	2.26	1.14	1.48	0.83	2.41	1.10	2.90	0.98
Single-valence mixed emotions								
Hope–joy	4.60	2.14	6.88	2.13	3.36	0.56	3.52	0.97
Fear–anger	3.78	1.39	3.28	0.56	4.42	1.67	3.65	1.47
Subjective ambivalence	2.90	1.52	1.96	1.05	2.81	1.44	3.94	1.34

Negative emotions were stronger with incongruent information ($M=2.50$) than for either congruent ($M=0.37$; $t=-0.956$, $p<0.01$) or conflicting information ($M=1.56$; $t=4.24$, $p<0.01$). Finally, conflicting information ($M=3.16$) elicited higher levels of objective ambivalence compared with congruent ($M=1.73$; $t=-7.32$, $p<0.01$) or incongruent information ($M=2.68$; $t=-2.43$, $p<0.03$).

In support of the first hypothesis, the within-subjects effect of emotion was significant ($F(3, 155)=14.59$, $p<0.01$). Within-subjects comparisons were used to test the predominance of anticipatory over outcome-based emotions. As expected, hope ($M=2.17$) was rated higher than joy ($M=1.70$; $F(1, 157)=23.14$, $p<0.01$; $\eta^2=0.13$), and fear ($M=1.61$) was higher than anger ($M=1.33$; $F(1, 157)=4.00$, $p<0.05$; $\eta^2=0.02$). Moreover, the hope–fear objective ambivalence ($M=2.78$) exceeded that of joy–anger ($M=2.26$; $F(1, 157)=23.08$, $p<0.01$; $\eta^2=0.15$). As expected, the results indicate that anticipatory emotions were experienced more strongly than outcome-based emotions given a prospective consumption situation (see Table 2). Furthermore, eta-squared values for the within-subject comparisons of hope and joy, as well as for hope–fear and joy–anger objective ambivalence, reveal a strong effect (Cohen, 1988), thus indicating that differences between anticipatory and outcome-based emotions explained a large percentage of variance. The difference for fear and anger, while significant, explained a smaller percentage of variance.

Although the congruence $\times$ emotion interaction was not significant ($p>0.05$), paired t -tests from within each level of congruence provide additional support for hypotheses H1a and H1c. With congruent information, hope ($M=4.77$) was found to be significantly greater than joy ($M=4.21$, $t(53)=2.95$, $p<0.01$). Conflicting information resulted in significantly higher hope–fear objective ambivalence ($M=3.42$) than joy–anger objective ambivalence ($M=2.90$; $t(53)=2.91$, $p<0.01$). However, differences were not found between fear ($M=2.42$) and anger ($M=2.58$; $t(51)=-0.57$, $p>0.05$) with incongruent information.

Ambivalence

Hierarchical regression was used to determine the unique contribution of hope–fear objective ambivalence on subjective ambivalence beyond that explained by the combinations of single-valence emotions and joy–anger objective ambivalence (see Table 3). The first step of the analysis involved regressing subjective ambivalence on the single-valence combinations of hope–joy and fear–anger. Next, joy–anger objective ambivalence was entered as a predictor. The final step included the entry of hope–fear objective ambivalence. When presented with a conflicting evaluation, it was expected that the final entry would explain a significant amount of incremental variance in subjective ambivalence.

With a conflicting restaurant evaluation, the first step of the regression indicated that single-valence emotions did not account for a significant amount of variance in subjective ambivalence. In the second step, joy–anger objective ambivalence was found to account for a significant amount of variance. More important, in the final step, hope–fear objective ambivalence contributed a significant amount of additional variance beyond that of joy–anger objective ambivalence. Moreover, the previously significant joy–anger objective ambivalence ceased to be significant in the presence of hope–fear objective ambivalence. This pattern of results supports the second hypothesis and indicates that hope–fear objective ambivalence makes a unique contribution to subjective ambivalence. Such a pattern was not found with either congruent or incongruent information. In these conditions, the final step of the hierarchical regression was not significant, indicating that hope–fear objective ambivalence did not account for additional variance (see Table 3).

In summary, anticipatory emotions were contrasted with outcome-based emotions in the context of an online restaurant review read prior to consumption. Although both categories of emotions were present, anticipatory emotions were experienced more intensely than outcome-based emotions. Compared with single-valence emotions and outcome-based emotions, the mixed emotion pair of hope and fear was the significant contributor to feelings of

Table 3. Hierarchical regression analysis predicting subjective ambivalence (Study 1)

Variables	Condition					
	Conflicting information		Congruent information		Incongruent information	
	β	R^2 change	β	R^2 change	β	R^2 change
Step 1: Single-valence emotion combinations		0.01		0.36**		0.12*
Hope-joy	0.03		-0.18		-0.30*	
Fear-anger	0.07		-0.56**		0.28*	
Step 2: Single-valence emotions and joy-anger OA		0.11*		0.07*		0.04
Hope-joy	0.01		0.18		-0.34**	
Fear-anger	0.14		-0.61**		0.35*	
Joy-anger objective ambivalence	0.34*		0.44*		0.20	
Step 3: SV emotions, joy-anger, and hope-fear OA		0.15**		0.02		0.06
Hope-joy	-0.04		0.10		-0.23	
Fear-anger	0.20		-0.42*		0.42*	
Joy-anger objective ambivalence	0.23		0.26		0.04	
Hope-fear objective ambivalence	0.42**		0.25		0.33	

Note: OA, objective ambivalence; SV, single valence.

* $p < 0.05$;

** $p < 0.01$.

subjective ambivalence during a prospective consumption situation. Thus, results from the first study demonstrate that anticipatory emotions are distinct from outcome-based emotions when considering future-oriented consumption. Given that many purchase and consumption decisions require consumers to consider uncertain future outcomes, it is also important to consider how anticipatory ambivalence affects consumer attitudes and behavior.

STUDY 2

The second study follows from the first by examining how anticipatory ambivalence in the context of a more involved and extensive prospective consumption situation affects attitudes and two types of intentions (delay and purchase). On the basis of our earlier findings, ambivalence is associated with feelings of discomfort and, in the case of prospective consumption, the specific feelings of hope and fear. What is not clear from Study 1 is how anticipatory ambivalence affects attitudes and behavior toward a prospective consumption situation. It seems likely that the effect of emotional ambivalence on intentions would differ based on a mixed-emotional state versus a single-valence state. In the second study, we explore these issues by examining how anticipatory ambivalence accounts for differences in prospective consumption attitudes and intentions.

Attitudes and intentions are important because they are precursors to behavior (Fishbein and Ajzen, 1975). Previous research has found that both evaluative information (e.g., quality) and attitudes have a direct effect on buying intentions (De Maeyer and Estelami, 2011; Hansen, 2005). Research on ambivalence indicates that feelings of discomfort alter the way consumers think and behave (e.g., Sparks *et al.*, 2001; Zemborain and Johar, 2007). For example, ambivalent individuals are more susceptible to persuasion (Zemborain and Johar, 2007) and are more likely to be

inconsistent in their expression of attitudes and intentions (Sparks *et al.*, 2001). However, previous research has not examined the effect of higher levels of ambivalence on the formation of judgments and how these judgments affect subsequent behaviors. In Study 2, we investigate how anticipatory ambivalence alters the way evaluative information directly affects intentions and also how it modifies the previously established attitude-intention relationship. Of particular interest is how anticipatory ambivalence mediates the effect of evaluative information on intentions and how it moderates the relationship between attitudes and intentions.

Ambivalence as a mediator

In contrast to previous research reporting that evaluative information has a direct effect on intentions (e.g., De Maeyer and Estelami, 2011), we consider the possibility that ambivalence acts as a mechanism through which conflicting evaluative information affects behavioral intentions. We know of only one study that has considered the mediating role of emotional ambivalence in decision making. Williams and Aaker (2002) found that emotional discomfort mediates the direct effect of mixed-emotional advertising appeals on attitude toward the ad but only for those individuals more (vs. less) prone to experiencing ambivalence. Along these same lines, we expect that ambivalence will mediate the direct effect of outcome desirability on intentions, but only for those exposed to conflicting information. This is due to increased ambivalence in the presence of conflicting information. Such a situation implies that evaluative information indirectly affects intentions through ambivalence. Mediation is not expected for those exposed to only congruent or incongruent information. Therefore, it is the emotional discomfort and uncertainty associated with conflicting information that underlies behavioral intentions toward a future purchase.

H3: Objective and subjective ambivalence will mediate the relationship between outcome desirability and intentions, but only for those exposed to a conflicting evaluation. Mediation is not expected for those receiving only congruent or incongruent information.

Ambivalence as a moderator

Attitudes often form the basis of intentions leading to behavior (Fishbein and Ajzen, 1975). Research has identified a number of variables that moderate the effect of attitudes on intentions (e.g., attitude accessibility and need for cognition; see Ajzen and Fishbein (2005) for a summary). Along these lines, ambivalence (both objective and subjective) is also expected to moderate this relationship. Previous research indicates that holding two conflicting feelings (e.g., hope and fear) or experiencing overall discomfort often leads to inconsistent evaluations or motives (Sparks *et al.*, 2001). Thus, in the case of prospective consumption, we suspect that lower levels of anticipatory ambivalence should characterize more consistent attitudes, and, as a result, be a better predictor of purchase intentions (Thompson *et al.*, 1995). By contrast, higher levels of ambivalence will correspond with unstable attitude evaluations, which will therefore be less predictive of purchase intentions. Accordingly, higher levels of ambivalence are predicted to weaken the effect of attitudes on intentions to purchase.

Also considered here are intentions to delay a purchase. Although previous research has examined attitudes and intention to purchase, limited research exists regarding delay as an avoidance behavior. There are many reasons that consumers delay a purchase (e.g., not enough time, need more information, and expect price drop; see Greenleaf and Lehmann (1995) for an extensive list). However, emotional uncertainty, particularly anticipatory ambivalence, has not yet been considered. Avoidance or delay is a common strategy used by consumers when making a difficult decision (e.g., choosing between products with conflicting attributes; Luce *et al.*, 1997). Thus, increased difficulty and discomfort associated with conflicting information results in a less stable attitude due to the presence of ambivalence. Such a situation is likely to lead consumers to want to postpone a purchase, thus strengthening the attitude–intention to delay relationship.

H4: Objective and subjective ambivalence will moderate the relationship between attitudes and intentions such that higher levels of ambivalence will (a) strengthen the

relationship between attitudes and likelihood of delay and (b) weaken the relationship between attitudes and likelihood of purchase.

Method

Participants were 129 undergraduate students. The procedure was identical to Study 1 except that a prospective purchase for a beachfront vacation resort was substituted for a restaurant as the study context. Vacations were selected because they are typically highly involving decisions. In addition, consumer evaluations about vacations tend to be highly subjective and multidimensional. Consumers take into account many different facets of the experience when selecting a destination, some of which may elicit positive, negative, or mixed emotions. In addition, industry reports indicate that young people are the strongest sector of the travel industry and will travel more than any other group, making them an important segment to consider (Battenbough, 2009). Respondents were presented with fictitious evaluative information about a vacation destination from ConsumerReports.org and corresponding customer comments. Using the attribute ratings from the report and customer comments, respondents were randomly assigned to one of three congruence conditions: a congruent condition containing desirable information, an incongruent condition with undesirable information, and a conflicting condition with both desirable and undesirable information (see Appendix).

Measures

The same set of items used in Study 1 were used to measure hope ($\alpha=0.91$) and fear ($\alpha=0.85$), as well as objective and subjective ($\alpha=0.91$) ambivalence. Attitude was assessed as an overall summary evaluation of the prospective situation based on the information provided, measured with three 7-point semantic differential scales: very bad/very good, very unfavorable/very favorable, and very negative/very positive ($\alpha=0.98$). Two intentions, likelihood of delay and likelihood of purchase, were also assessed. Respondents were asked how likely they would engage in each behavior, measured using a 7-point scale ranging from 1 (*not at all likely*) to 7 (*very likely*). The correlations among constructs are reported in Table 4.

Dummy-coded contrasts were created to represent the different levels of congruence to be used as predictors in the test of mediation in the third hypothesis. The first predictor, C_1 ,

Table 4. Correlations of constructs (Study 2)

		1	2	3	4	5	6
1	Hope	1.0					
2	Fear	−0.45**	1.0				
3	Hope–fear	−0.04	0.24**	1.0			
4	Subjective ambivalence	−0.05	0.19*	0.39**	1.0		
5	Delay	−0.42**	0.34**	0.25**	0.13	1.0	
6	Purchase	0.75**	−0.49**	−0.04	−0.01	−0.56**	1.0

Note:

* $p < 0.05$;

** $p < 0.01$.

contrasts the congruent with the conflicting condition ($C_1 = 0$ if congruent and $C_1 = 1$ if conflicting), and the second variable, C_2 , contrasts the congruent and incongruent conditions ($C_2 = 0$ if congruent and $C_2 = 1$ if incongruent). Thus, if a positive effect were found in the case of C_1 on delay, that would indicate that delay is greater given conflicting information compared with congruent information.

Results and discussion

Manipulation checks

As a check on the effectiveness of the congruence manipulation, ANOVAs were conducted with hope, fear, hope–fear objective ambivalence, and subjective ambivalence (see Table 5 for means). As expected, congruence had a significant effect on hope ($F(2, 118) = 77.60, p < 0.01$), fear ($F(2, 118) = 22.16, p < 0.01$), hope–fear objective ambivalence ($F(2, 118) = 7.01, p < 0.01$), and subjective ambivalence ($F(2, 118) = 9.93, p < 0.01$). Congruent information ($M = 4.66$) resulted in greater hope than incongruent ($M = 0.65; t(118) = 12.08, p < 0.01$) or conflicting ($M = 3.52; t(118) = 3.45, p < 0.01$) information. Exposure to incongruent information ($M = 3.07$) resulted in higher levels of fear compared with congruent ($M = 0.89; t(118) = 6.51, p < 0.01$) or conflicting ($M = 3.52; t(118) = 4.47, p < 0.01$) information. Conflicting information ($M_{\text{objamb}} = 3.62; M_{\text{subamb}} = 3.85$) generated greater ambivalence than either congruent ($M_{\text{objamb}} = 2.35; t(118) = 3.51, p < 0.01; M_{\text{subamb}} = 2.51; t(118) = 4.31, p < 0.01$) or incongruent ($M_{\text{objamb}} = 2.59; t(118) = 2.86, p < 0.01; M_{\text{subamb}} = 2.88; t(118) = 3.12, p < 0.01$) information. This pattern of results replicates those of Study 1.

Ambivalence as a mediator

The mediation analysis followed the procedure of Baron and Kenny (1986). Sobel tests were used to assess the mediating effect of objective and subjective ambivalence. In summary, a total of eight models were examined on the basis of a combination of the following: two independent variables ($C_1 = 0$ if congruent information and 1 if conflicting information; and $C_2 = 0$ if congruent information and 1 if incongruent information), two mediators (subjective and objective ambivalence), and two dependent variables (purchase and delay). Tests of mediation were conducted separately for each combination of independent variable, mediator, and

dependent variable. Table 6 displays the standardized regression coefficients, significance levels, and Sobel results. Overall, the regression results support H3. Subjective and objective ambivalence were each found to mediate the effect of outcome desirability on intentions for those exposed to conflicting information. Given that mediation results were the same for both objective and subjective ambivalence, the term ambivalence is used to refer to either objective or subjective ambivalence in the following description of mediation.

First, the congruent versus conflicting contrast (C_1) had a significant effect on the mediator such that ambivalence increased with conflicting information. Second, C_1 had a significant direct effect on the dependent variables of likelihood of delay and purchase when it was the sole predictor of the model. Conflicting information resulted in increased delay and decreased purchase intent. Most notably, in the final step, when C_1 and ambivalence were entered as predictors of delay and purchase, ambivalence had a significant effect on both measures. Greater ambivalence increased delay and decreased purchase intent. However, this entry reduced the direct effect of C_1 on both intentions measures to non-significance. This analysis indicates that conflicting information had an indirect effect on intentions through ambivalence. The same tests of mediation were conducted with the congruent versus incongruent contrast (C_2) as the independent variable. As expected, ambivalence did not mediate the effect of C_2 on intentions. Collectively, these analyses indicate that feelings of ambivalence mediate the relationship between outcome desirability and intentions, but only for those exposed to conflicting information.

Ambivalence as a moderator

The final hypothesis predicts that objective and subjective ambivalence each moderate the effect of attitudes on intentions. Analyses were conducted separately for objective and subjective ambivalence, as well as for the dependent variables of likelihood of delay and purchase. The procedure outlined in Aiken and West (1991) was followed for testing interactions between continuous variables. First, attitude and each ambivalence measure were mean-centered. Next, two interaction terms were created on the basis of the product of the mean-centered predictors: (i) attitude and objective

Table 5. Means and standard deviations (Study 2)

	Condition							
	Overall		Congruent information ($n = 40$)		Incongruent information ($n = 40$)		Conflicting information ($n = 41$)	
	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>
Emotions								
Hope	2.95	2.24	4.66	1.61	0.65	1.06	3.52	1.69
Fear	1.84	1.74	0.89	1.08	3.07	1.94	1.58	1.35
Hope–fear objective ambivalence	2.86	1.70	2.35	1.76	2.59	1.44	3.62	1.66
Subjective ambivalence	3.09	1.49	2.51	1.78	2.88	1.64	3.85	1.32
Attitudes	4.24	1.96	6.20	0.64	1.93	1.01	4.59	0.89
Delay	5.07	1.83	4.13	1.88	6.00	1.47	5.07	1.66
Purchase	3.87	2.06	5.40	1.39	1.80	1.27	4.39	1.53

Table 6. Regression and Sobel tests of mediation predicting delay and purchase (Study 2)

Relationship (predictor → criterion)	Delay		Purchase	
	β congruent vs. conflicting (C ₁)	β congruent vs. incongruent (C ₂)	β congruent vs. conflicting (C ₁)	β congruent vs. incongruent (C ₂)
Objective ambivalence				
1. Contrast → objective ambivalence	0.35**	0.08	0.35**	0.08
2. Contrast → intention (without objective ambivalence)	0.26**	0.49**	−0.33**	−0.81**
3. Objective ambivalence → intention (with contrast)	0.42**	0.17	−0.30**	−0.06
Contrast → intention (with objective ambivalence)	0.11	0.48**	−0.22	−0.80**
Sobel test	2.56**	0.62	−2.10*	−0.51
Subjective ambivalence				
1. Contrast → subjective ambivalence	0.48**	0.13	0.48**	0.13
2. Contrast → intention (without subjective ambivalence)	0.26**	0.49**	−0.33**	−0.81**
3. Subjective ambivalence → intention (with contrast)	0.40**	−0.01	−0.26*	0.01
Contrast → intention (with subjective ambivalence)	0.07	0.49**	−0.22	−0.81**
Sobel test	2.80**	−0.14	−1.99*	0.15

Note: Independent variables: C₁ = 0 if congruent and 1 if conflicting; C₂ = 0 if congruent and 1 if incongruent.

* $p < 0.05$;

** $p < 0.01$.

ambivalence and (ii) attitude and subjective ambivalence. Hierarchical regression was conducted to determine whether additional variance was accounted for by the interaction beyond any main effects. The mean-centered predictors were entered in the first step, followed by the interaction term (see Table 7).

Across all four models, the main effects of attitude and ambivalence collectively explained a significant amount variance in intentions in the first step. Attitude was a consistent predictor of intentions in all four models, whereas only

one ambivalence predictor (i.e., objective ambivalence delay, see Table 7) was significant. More important, in the second step, the interaction of attitude and ambivalence contributed a significant amount of additional variance in all four models. Specifically, a significant positive interaction of attitude and ambivalence on likelihood of delay was found for both objective ($\beta = 0.17$, $p < 0.05$) and subjective ($\beta = 0.30$, $p < 0.01$) ambivalence. The findings indicate that as ambivalence increases, the effect

Table 7. Hierarchical regression analysis predicting delay and purchase (Study 2)

Variables	Delay		Purchase	
	β	R^2 change	β	R^2 change
Objective ambivalence				
Step 1		0.24**		0.57**
Attitude	−0.43**		0.75**	
Objective ambivalence	0.26**		−0.05	
Step 2		0.02*		0.03**
Attitude	−0.37**		0.69**	
Ambivalence	0.22**		−0.01	
Attitude × objective ambivalence	0.17*		−0.20**	
Subjective ambivalence				
Step 1		0.19**		0.57**
Attitude	−0.41**		0.76**	
Subjective ambivalence	0.09		0.09	
Step 2		0.08**		0.02*
Attitude	−0.32**		0.72**	
Ambivalence	0.14		0.07	
Attitude × subjective ambivalence	0.30**		−0.14*	

Note:

* $p < 0.05$;

** $p < 0.01$.

of attitude on delay likelihood is strengthened. Conversely, a negative interaction of attitude and ambivalence was found on purchase likelihood for both objective ($\beta = -0.20$, $p < 0.01$) and subjective ($\beta = -0.14$, $p < 0.05$) ambivalence. A negative interaction indicates that as ambivalence increases, the effect of attitudes on purchase likelihood weakens. Results support the final hypothesis that ambivalence moderates the relationship between attitudes and intentions.

In sum, the results of the second study suggest that anticipatory ambivalence has a dual mediating and moderating role. Ambivalence was found to mediate the relationship between evaluative information and intentions, but only for those exposed to conflicting information. In this case, ambivalence is an important factor in explaining the likelihood of purchase and delay when consumers receive conflicting information. In addition, with higher levels of ambivalence, we were able to demonstrate a strengthening (attenuation) of the relationship between attitudes and intention to delay (purchase).

GENERAL DISCUSSION

The consideration of anticipatory emotions in a consumer behavior context provides both theoretical and practical insights. Uncertainty over a prospective purchase is quite common, particularly when the consequences of making the wrong choice matter. The specific emotions of hope and fear, as well as anticipatory ambivalence, were identified as distinctive emotional experiences that occur in response to future consumption events. Considering this future-oriented outlook provides an opportunity to examine thoughts, feelings, and behaviors from a relatively under-researched perspective in the purchase–consumption process. Anticipatory ambivalence was found to mediate the relationship between conflicting evaluations and intentions, as well as moderate the relationship between attitudes and intentions. In both cases, anticipatory ambivalence had a negative effect on attitudes and intentions. The subsequent discussion integrates our findings with previous research and identifies the implications associated with a future temporal perspective and anticipatory emotions.

Identifying when specific emotions are relevant and influential in the consumer decision-making process is important (Ruth *et al.*, 2002). Yet, despite this, little research had been conducted on emotional reactions to prospective consumption events. It is argued that a future-directed perspective is quite common given that consumers rarely make a decision without giving some thought to how the purchase will work out. It follows then that anticipatory emotions play an important role in many consumption situations. The first study reported here contributes to the consumer emotion literature by demonstrating a conceptual contrast such that the anticipatory emotions of hope and fear are more predominant than outcome-based emotions (joy and anger) when considering future consumption.

Hope and fear have been examined separately in prior research (e.g., Baumgartner *et al.*, 2008; Winterich and

Haws, 2011), but the combination of these emotions and their associated effects have not been previously considered. The current research is, to our knowledge, the first attempt to investigate the combined effect of both hope and fear in terms of anticipatory objective ambivalence. Research by Priester and Petty (1996) suggested that objective ambivalence is a function of both the discrete positive and negative attitudes that people have in response to a target and is antecedent to the summary state of subjective ambivalence. We extend their research by accounting for single-valence and outcome-based emotion combinations. We find that the mixture of hope and fear is more predictive of subjective ambivalence than is the combination of joy and anger. The key differentiator in eliciting hope and fear over joy and anger was uncertainty about the outcome. In sum, the results clearly indicate that hope and fear are integral contributors to buyer discomfort given an uncertain future consumption outcome.

In the second study, we examined how consumer ambivalence is related to consumer attitudes and behaviors. Operationalized in terms of consumer discomfort, ambivalence was found to play both a moderating and mediating role. Previous research by Williams and Aaker (2002) identified emotional discomfort as a mediator between mixed-emotional advertising appeals and attitude toward the ad for individuals more (vs. less) prone to experiencing ambivalence. Our research supports and extends their results by considering the mediating role of anticipatory ambivalence in the context of prospective consumption. Similar to those individuals with a higher propensity to experience ambivalence, anticipatory ambivalence mediated the relationship between evaluative information and behavioral intentions, but only for those exposed to conflicting (vs. congruent or incongruent information). The finding indicates that it is not just conflicting information that influences behavior but also consumers' subsequent emotional response (i.e., ambivalence) to such information that leads consumers to be more cautious about making a purchase decision.

Research has consistently found a predictive relationship between attitudes toward an object and intentions to act (Fishbein and Ajzen, 1975). Previous research has identified several moderators of this relationship, such as attitude accessibility and need for cognition. Along these same lines, we find that anticipatory ambivalence also alters this long-established linkage. Building on Sparks *et al.* (2001), who found that attitudinal ambivalence weakens the predictive ability of attitudes on intentions to consume meat and chocolate, our research found that emotional ambivalence attenuates the relationship between attitudes and purchase intentions. It is interesting that, when considering delay, a variable not previously examined with ambivalence, the results indicate a strengthening of the attitude–intentions relationship. Thus, increased discomfort and a less stable attitude due to the presence of ambivalence increase the likelihood of delaying a purchase. Overall, the consensus

of our findings supports the idea that uncertainty and its related emotions have a consistent, pervasive negative impact on subsequent thoughts and behaviors.

MANAGERIAL IMPLICATIONS

Although products are often created to either promote hopes or alleviate fears, it is not unusual for both emotions to also coexist in a consumption situation. Understanding how anticipatory ambivalence over the prospects of uncertain outcomes affects attitudes and purchase intentions should therefore be relevant to marketing managers. Four managerial implications are highlighted. First, it is inevitable that consumers will, at some point, be exposed to conflicting messages regarding a possible purchase. This is especially likely given the extensive evaluative information available to consumers (e.g., traditional and social media). Thus, given a situation where conflicting information is present, one implication is for marketers to manage ambivalence by providing consumers with consistent messaging such as that highlighted in a strategy of integrated marketing communications (McGrath, 2005). Such messaging emphasizes positive outcomes, thus maximizing hope while minimizing fear.

A related implication is specific to hope and fear. An awareness of emotions likely to occur earlier in the purchase–consumption process (i.e., hope and fear) and why they occur (i.e., uncertainty) might allow marketers to intervene so as to manage these anticipatory responses. Besides consistent messaging, reducing uncertainty is also likely to mitigate feelings of ambivalence prior to a purchase. Several possibilities exist for reducing uncertainty, such as product warranties, return policies, easy access to information, free samples or trials, and reassurance from other customers.

A third implication of our research is for marketers to minimize the importance of those consumption facets that cannot easily be addressed. One way to do this is to deemphasize the importance of less favorable product attributes. For example, Motel 6 directly addressed consumers' fears about the quality of amenities available at their budget hotel chain. The company ran a series of ads emphasizing those facets of a lodging property that should be most important (e.g., comfortable bed, clean rooms, and low price) and deemphasized less critical attributes (e.g., nicely furnished lobbies, room service, and expensive restaurants). The ads then explained how well Motel 6 performed in satisfying consumer desires on these most important attributes.

A final implication concerns the prediction of customer behavior based on marketing research. Two issues from our research arise in predicting behavior: accounting for the complexity of emotional experiences (Williamson, 2002) and the role of ambivalence. Anticipatory emotions are relevant to future-oriented consumption experiences. This finding points to the importance of specific emotions depending on the situation and stage of consumption. Therefore, in order to make better predictions, marketing researchers should consider a broad range of emotions likely to be salient at different points of the purchase and consumption process. In addition, marketers often predict behavior with attitudes and intentions.

However, ambivalence alters how information and attitudes affect intentions. Therefore, accounting for ambivalence would increase the usefulness of assessment tools, improve the accuracy of predictions, and provide a better understanding of customers.

LIMITATIONS AND FUTURE RESEARCH

Our experimental approach enhanced internal validity and provided a test of the effect of outcome desirability and prospective consumption on emotional response, attitudes, and intentions. Yet a lab setting may not be representative of everyday consumption. As a result, the intensity of emotional response may have actually been less than what would occur in an actual consumption situation. Therefore, the study of emotional response would benefit from alternative approaches such as interviews and observations (Otnes *et al.*, 1997).

Uncertainty is an important appraisal dimension in the elicitation of anticipatory emotions (Lerner and Keltner, 2000; Ortony *et al.*, 1988) and is inherent in prospective consumption decisions. However, it should be noted that uncertainty was not directly assessed in our research. Future research should directly assess uncertainty and examine its role in emotional experiences, ambivalence, and consumer responses. Ambivalence is associated with feelings of conflict and discomfort (Priester and Petty, 1996; van Harreveld *et al.*, 2009), whereas uncertainty is associated with not having knowledge about an event (Lee and Qiu, 2009). It might be expected that feelings of uncertainty function in a similar way to ambivalence, increasing in future-directed situations and altering relationships among variables.

The current research focused on how conflicting information influences feelings and emotions as well as subsequent behavioral intentions with a particular focus on the effects of future-directed appraisals. It is worth noting that a related area of inquiry is the expectation–disconfirmation model (e.g., Oliver, 1993; Phillips and Baumgartner, 2002; Santos and Boote, 2003), which considers affective states arising from the confirmation or disconfirmation of prepurchase expectations. Although the genesis of anticipatory emotions and confirmation/disconfirmation emotions rely on appraisals of prospective events (Ortony *et al.*, 1988), an important distinction is that the former is premised on events that are yet to be known, whereas the latter are the result of a comparison between an actual outcome and an expectation (Ortony *et al.*, 1988). In other words, the focus of our research was on emotions felt in anticipation of an outcome, not those arising after the outcome is known. Future research would benefit from an examination of the interplay of expectations, future-directed and confirmation/disconfirmation emotions, and subsequent thoughts and behaviors.

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APPENDIX A

INFORMATION CONTAINED IN SCENARIOS

Study 1: A pretest was used to identify attributes important in selecting a restaurant and also to examine the effectiveness of the manipulations. Sixty-one undergraduate students rated the importance of attributes selected from various restaurant evaluations (1 = *not at all important* and 7 = *very important*). Mean importance ratings ranged from 4.38 to 6.46 with an overall mean of 5.40. The lowest rating (4.38) was significantly different from the scale midpoint of 4.0 ($t(60) = 2.15, p < 0.05$), indicating attributes were important.

Restaurant attribute ratings

	Congruent ^a	Incongruent ^a	Conflicting1 ^{a,b}	Conflicting2 ^{a,b}
Food	Excellent	Poor	Fair	Very good
Décor	Very good	Fair	Very good	Fair
Service	Excellent	Poor	Poor	Excellent
Atmosphere	Very good	Fair	Excellent	Poor
Value	Very good	Fair	Fair	Very good
Parking	Excellent	Poor	Very good	Fair
Overall	Excellent	Poor	Good	Good

^aPlanned contrasts revealed that positive and negative ratings were significantly different across all conditions.

^bNo differences were observed between the two conflicting conditions for positive ($p > 0.39$) and negative ($p > 0.15$) ratings, hope–fear objective ambivalence (OA; $p > 0.50$), joy–anger OA ($p > 0.61$), and subjective ambivalence ($p > 0.47$).

The following comments were matched to the aforementioned ratings:

“Great (unpleasant) atmosphere where the décor is tasteful (dated), the service and staff are outstanding (dreadful), and the food is very (not) good.”

“I thought it was fairly(over) priced.”

“Easy(difficult), accessible (out-of-the-way) parking.”

“Excellent (terrible) location, (not) great food and (un)friendly staff: I’ll definitely (not) be going back.”

Study 2: A pretest was conducted with 43 undergraduate students to rate the importance of attributes selected from a number of vacation brochures thought to be important to students in evaluating a beachfront resort (1 = *not at all important* and 7 = *very important*). Attribute ratings ranged from 4.55 to 5.83 with an overall mean rating of 5.41. The mean of the lowest rated attribute (4.55) was significantly different from the scale midpoint of 4.0 ($t(42) = 2.00, p < 0.05$), indicating that selected attributes were important in selecting a vacation destination.

Vacation attribute ratings

	Congruent ^a	Incongruent ^b	Conflicting1 ^{a,b}	Conflicting2 ^{a,b}
Service	Excellent	Poor	Excellent	Poor
Accommodations	Excellent	Poor	Good	Good
Natural surroundings	Very good	Fair	Excellent	Poor
Outdoor activities	Very good	Fair	Fair	Very good
Entertainment	Very good	Fair	Very good	Fair
Restaurants	Excellent	Poor	Poor	Excellent
Shopping	Very good	Fair	Poor	Excellent
Overall	Excellent	Poor	Good	Good

^aPlanned contrasts revealed that positive and negative ratings were significantly different across all conditions.

^bNo differences were observed between the two conflicting conditions for positive ($p > 0.94$) and negative ($p > 0.56$) ratings, hope–fear OA ($p > 0.99$), joy–anger OA ($p > 0.38$), and subjective ambivalence ($p > 0.41$).

The following comments were matched to the aforementioned ratings:

“This resort was (not) a lot fun because it offered (failed to offer) several of my favorite activities, like scuba diving, parachute sailing, water-skiing, golf, and tennis.”

“The shopping and nightclubbing exceeded (did not live up to) my expectations.”

“The amenities were of a higher (lower) quality than most resorts in this price range.”

“The natural surroundings where the resort was located were above (sub) par.”

“I was very satisfied (dissatisfied) with the quality of the service delivered by resort employees.”

“I was delighted (disappointed) with the number and quality of restaurants in the area and at the resort.”

BIOGRAPHICAL NOTES

Colleen Bee (PhD, University of Oregon) is an assistant professor of marketing in the College of Business at Oregon State University. Her research examines consumer responses to media and marketing messages, including entertainment, advertising, and sponsorship.

Robert Madrigal (PhD, University of Oregon) is an associate professor of marketing in the Lundquist College of Business at the University of Oregon. His research focuses on consumer psychology across a variety of contexts including high-suspense entertainment (e.g., sports and movies), corporate sponsorship, charitable giving, and marketplace deception.

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